fishes. However, in the later burials the pots carry the names of the dead, inscribed in local characters clearly derived from the Brahmi alphabet but adapted to allow for elements in spoken Tamil, hence ‘Tamil-Brahmi’. So far, more than a hundred shards of pottery have been uncovered bearing characters in Tamil-Brahmi script, which Rajan and his colleagues initially dated from well-stratified layers to the third century BCE but subsequently revised to the fourth century BCE.

Subsequently, a second cist burial site was excavated at Porunthal, also in Tamil Nadu but some 90 kilometres due south of Kodumanal. This was also sited on an ancient trade route, running through the Western Ghats from Madurai. Here grave goods from four graves excavated in 2009 and 2010 included pots containing grains of rice, two samples of which were subjected to radiometric measurement by Accelerator Mass Spectometry (AMS) to give datings of 490 BCE and 450 BCE. This was clear evidence of paddy being cultivated in that area at that date. However, this early AMS dating was further said to prove the existence of Tamil-Brahmi writing at that same period. ‘For the first time,’ wrote Professor Rajan and his colleague, Dr V. P. Yatheeskumar, in 2013, ‘an AMS date is obtained for a grave that is associated with Brahmi script … Thus the AMS date obtained for the paddy grains from the Porunthal site has the following implications: the Brahmi writing system in India can be pushed back to fifth century BCE.’[2]

Such a dating would turn the history of writing in South Asia on its head. However, its critics argue that its authors have not satisfactorily established the link between the inscribed potsherd found in the Porunthal excavation and the dated rice grains. My own view is that more and better evidence will have to be produced before the text-books are rewritten on the issue of the first appearance of Brahmi in India.